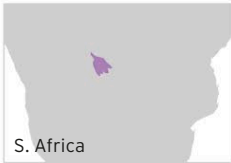


The Okavango Delta

A vast inland delta in southern Africa, an oasis within the Kalahari Desert that attracts millions of animals on annual migrations



The Okavango Delta is a gently sloping inland delta in northwestern Botswana. It is fed by the Okavango River, which flows southeastward from its source in Angola through the Kalahari Desert but never reaches the ocean. Instead, its water drains into a depression in the Kalahari Basin, where it spreads out to create an oasis comprising permanent and seasonally flooded marshlands, grassland plains, islands, and waterways. The annual flooding of the delta by water that fell as rain in the Angolan highlands, more than 620 miles

(1,000km) away, swells it to three times its usual size. Coinciding with Botswana’s dry season, the flooding attracts a huge influx of animals, including herbivores such as buffaloes and elephants, creating one of the greatest concentrations of wildlife in Africa. Over 97 percent of the water that enters the delta evaporates or eventually seeps into the sand of the Kalahari Desert. What is left drains into Lake Ngami to the west.



◁ **BOLD MARKINGS**
Marbled reed frogs display a large range of colors and markings with a combination of stripes, spots, and dashes.



◁ **FLAT DELTA**
The Okavango Delta is mostly flat, with less than 6 ft (2m) variation in height across the area. The pattern of its waterways changes every year as channels become blocked and the slow-moving water finds a new route.

ENDORHEIC BASINS

The Okavango Delta is part of an endorheic basin—a drainage system that has no outlet to the sea. These basins usually converge on a lake or swamp. Most endorheic basins are located in arid areas, and most water that enters evaporates.

A diagram showing the Okavango River flowing into the Okavango Delta. The river is labeled "Okavango River" and the delta is labeled "Okavango Delta". The diagram illustrates the branching pattern of the river as it enters the delta.